

IN HIGH SPIRITS
Anil Kapoor in
The Night Manager

Anil Kapoor loves an audience. Seated at the JW Marriott in Juhu, Mumbai, with two bowls of fruits placed in front of him, Kapoor looks for a reaction as he shares an amusing anecdote about filmmaker-producer Vidhu Vinod Chopra or talks about how a recent Instagram post of his was appreciated. He gives no impression that he is 66 years old. His fitness regimen and age-defying abilities are a source of much amusement on social media where, in a clever pun, he is referred to as "*Baal kalakaar* [child artiste]". The actor is flattered with his popularity among those even younger than his 30-something kids. "It's a huge compliment, but I am not delusional," he says, aware of the fleeting nature of internet fame. His own kids, all of whom work in films, he says, don't take him seriously.

What matters most is that Kapoor takes his work seriously and it's why he is enjoying the most prolific phase of his career. He continues to strike a chord with his audience as he did recently when he shared a clip from his debut Hindi film, *Woh Saat Din* (1983), to celebrate his 40th anniversary in the film industry. In the caption, he labelled himself both an actor and "entertainer". "Entertaining is also acting," he says. "People say, '*Yeh actor theek hai, lekin saala jab screen pe aata hai nazar nahin hatti* (He is an OK actor but boy once he comes on screen, you cannot take your eyes off him)'. I must be doing something right. You want to do certain things as an actor, leader or writer and chief among them is that your work connects."

IN 1989, INDIA TODAY DUBBED ANIL KAPOOR 'THE JOKER IN THE PACK'. IT'S A MONIKER HE CONTINUES TO OWN WITH APLOMB

It's what Kapoor does well in *The Night Manager* (2023), whose first season just concluded with its fifth, sixth and seventh episodes dropping on Disney+ Hotstar. Kapoor is Shelly, a wanted weapons supplier with a hunger for power, money, a luxurious lifestyle, and plenty of swag. It's a flamboyant performance that ensures you 'can't take your eyes off him' even if he is an immoral businessman. Instead of judging the character, Kapoor chose to delve into Shelly's rags-to-riches story and self-made credentials to understand why he is the way he is. Says Kapoor, "It's my job to make the character exciting. You draw on all kinds of emotions that happen in every relationship. So you feel for him, be it love or hate."

The Night Manager marks Kapoor's OTT debut. Prior to it, he became one of the few film actors to lead a Hindi TV show in *24* (2013-14, 2016). Before that he made headlines as the lively host of a game show in the Oscar-winning *Slumdog Millionaire* (2008). "When you do something that nobody has done, and if that succeeds, then the happiness you get is unparalleled," he says.

Validation is all that he has sought, he says, in his four decades in front of the camera. Kapoor realises it's no easy feat to be part of the conversation. "I've been fortunate and blessed in terms of choices, relationships and family.... All of them play a role," he says. His hard work and varied choices have contributed to his longevity. Kapoor's endeavour is pure and simple: deliver memorable performances, avoid work that you will regret decades later and give the makers more than they expect.

This eagerness to surrender, to take that extra step in the 1980s and '90s, didn't do his reputation any favours, he feels. "They called me a boring man who is on time, self-obsessed about work, who puts on and loses weight for the part. '*Sirf kaam ki baat karta hai* (Only talks about work)'," says Kapoor, listing out the litany of